The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Hours before the ceasefire between **America** and **Iran** was due to expire on Wednesday, there was no agreement on extending it or holding fresh talks. Iran said it had not yet decided whether to attend negotiations in Pakistan; J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, had reportedly not departed America. Only three ships passed the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, according to MarineTraffic, a ship-tracking platform.

Israel's armed forces accused **Hizbullah**, an Iran-backed militia, of breaching an American-brokered ceasefire in Lebanon after firing rockets at its troops in southern Lebanon. It was the first such incident since the truce began last week. Israel also said it intercepted a drone. It maintains its forces can still strike militants in a self-declared "security zone".

Kevin Warsh, Donald Trump's pick to lead the Federal Reserve, told senators he would be "strictly independent". At a tense confirmation hearing, he said the president had not made him promise to lower interest rates, and said America's central bank had "lost its way". Thom Tillis, a Republican, has threatened to block Mr Warsh's confirmation unless a probe into **Jerome Powell**, the current chair, is dropped.

Shippers UPS and **FedEx** began filing requests for refunds on **tariffs** after the Supreme Court ruled that some duties were unconstitutional. Apple and Amazon are among the firms that have not yet filed for refunds. In an interview with CNBC Mr Trump said he would "remember" companies that opted not to seek reimbursements to avoid offending him. The bill for refunds could soar to $166bn.

Ukraine said it has repaired the Druzhba **pipeline**, a major Soviet-era oil route carrying Russian crude to central Europe, and is ready to resume operations, potentially restoring flows to Hungary and Slovakia. The move could end a months-long dispute that delayed a €90bn EU loan. **Hungary** and Slovakia had blocked the funding until supplies resumed, linking energy flows to financial support.

Japan relaxed restrictions on exports of **lethal weapons**, departing from pacifist policies introduced after the second world war. The shift comes as Japan builds up its armed forces, prompted by rising regional tensions and a drive to support allies in the Middle East and Ukraine. Previously, Japan limited overseas sales of military kit to equipment that carried out such tasks as minesweeping, rescue, surveillance, transport and warning.

Taiwan's president, Lai Ching-te, cancelled a trip to **Eswatini** because China made travel impossible, his office said. Madagascar, Mauritius and Seychelles refused to allow his plane through their airspace. Taiwan alleged that they had been coerced by China, including with economic pressure. Eswatini is one of 12 countries that have formal diplomatic relations with Taiwan, which China claims as its own.

Figure of the day: $20bn, the potential value of Anduril's ten-year contract with America's army. Read about how defence technology upstarts are changing war.

Photograph: Reuters

Trump’s Fed pick begins his audition

Kevin Warsh, Donald Trump’s nominee for chair of the Federal Reserve, faced questions from the Senate Banking Committee on Tuesday. Although he provided polished answers—including refuting a senator’s suggestion that he would be Mr Trump’s “human sock puppet”—senators may not confirm Mr Warsh before Jerome Powell’s term ends on May 15th. Thom Tillis, a Republican member of the committee, has vowed to block Mr Warsh’s appointment unless the Department of Justice drops a spurious investigation into Mr Powell over the bill for renovating the Fed’s headquarters. Mr Powell has said he could stay on as chair temporarily; Donald Trump has threatened to fire him (though he almost certainly lacks that power).

Even if the political storm blows over, the job looks newly tricky. An erstwhile inflation hawk, Mr Warsh won over Mr Trump by arguing for a reduction in interest rates. Since then war in Iran has pushed up inflation, making rate cuts tougher to justify. If Mr Warsh keeps rates high, he may join Mr Powell in the president’s bad books.

Photograph: Getty Images

South Korea turns to a new central bank chief

The Bank of Korea welcomed a new governor, Shin Hyun-song, on Tuesday. The former top adviser at the Bank of International Settlements, a forum for central banks, has a reputation for spotting impending crises. This time the danger is clear. His ascent to the top job comes as South Korea faces uncertainty caused by soaring oil prices and a weakening won.

War in the Middle East is particularly painful for South Korea's economy. Last week, import prices posted their steepest rise in nearly three decades, led by raw materials and oil-related products. During his confirmation hearing, Mr Shin acknowledged soaring prices but played down risks of stagflation, fears of which are mounting. When he was nominated, some commentators called Mr Shin a "practical hawk". He rejects the label, but is widely expected to raise interest rates, which his predecessor has held steady for a year. The question is how soon he will act.

New heights

South Korea, import price index, 2020=100

Sources: Bank of Korea; Haver Analytics

Photograph: Getty Images

Virginia is for redistricters, maybe

Voters in Virginia will decide in a referendum on Tuesday whether the state can use a new electoral map in the midterm elections in November. In February Abigail Spanberger, the Democratic governor, approved a revision that would probably give her party four more seats in America's Congress. Supporters say it reflects changes to Virginia's electorate. Opponents argue that it disadvantages rural voters. The dispute has drawn national attention and big money. Last week Barack Obama told Virginians that voting "yes" was their chance to "level the playing field".

Virginia's vote, as Mr Obama was implying, is part of a national fight. It began in Texas last summer when, at Donald Trump's urging, the state redrew its electoral map to help Republicans win more seats in Congress. That provoked counter-moves, and counter-counter-moves, by both Republican and Democratic states. California (blue) and Missouri, North Carolina and Utah (all red) have changed their maps. Virginia and three others are waiting for the green light.

Photograph: Explosive Media

Iran lands a propaganda punch

Iran's theocratic regime is not known for its sense of humour. But in today's Gulf war, it appears to be winning the propaganda battle against the home of Hollywood.

Day after day, Explosive Media—an Iran-based firm that claims to be independent—churns out videos, made quickly and cheaply with AI, that ridicule Donald Trump and glorify those who resist him. The soundtrack is often thumping rap, with English lyrics. The figures are frequently made of Lego. Donald Trump is portrayed as a cowardly liar who declares victory even as his pants are, literally, on fire. Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, is shown as a vomiting drunk with crusader tattoos.

"Music's got the whole world dancing while the truth sneaks out between the beats," one TikToker commented. An unpopular American president waging an unpopular war gives the videos a mockable target. But look closely and the agenda is obvious: ever-victorious Iranian forces, antisemitic imagery and conspiracy theories routinely feature. America's State Department used to have an office to counter enemy disinformation. The Trump administration closed it last year.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which port and naval base was ceded to Britain by Spain in the 1713 Treaty of Utrecht?

Monday: Which Danish explorer spent many years leading expeditions for the Russian navy in the 18th century?

Books are for people who wish they were somewhere else.

Mark Twain